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# New Epstein Photos Show Trump, Bill Clinton, Bill Gates & Others; House GOP Unveils Health Care Bill Without Enhanced Subsidies; Group Describes Machado's Perilous Journey To Norway. Aired 12-1a ET

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ELEX MICHAELSON, CNN HOST: -- on Monday night right here on "The Story Is". Laura Coates in studio with me.

LAURA COATES, CNN HOST: Oh my Gosh. I can't wait.

MICHAELSON: So, that is reason to watch.

COATES: That's my jackpot.

MICHAELSON: Well, that's -- we call it deep tease. That's the jackpot. And if I win this weekend, you get to do the whole show.

COATES: Somehow that's not the way this is supposed to go. OK. Have a great show. Good night.

MICHAELSON: All right. Have a good weekend. "The Story Is" starts right now.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

UNIDENTIFIED MALE (voice-over): "The Story Is", new photos of Jeffrey Epstein released as part of the investigation. We explore the connection to the Clintons.

"The Story Is", escaping Venezuela.

BRYAN STERN, FOUNDER, GREY BULL RESCUE FOUNDATION: This is the hardest, most high-profile, most delicate operation we've conducted.

UNIDENTIFIED MALE (voice-over): Why, despite the warning, opposition leader Machado is vowing to return.

"The Story Is", California politics.

MICHAELSON: You said that you were not going to run for governor of California. Now there is reports that you're thinking about it. Is that true?

ROB BONTA, CALIFORNIA ATTORNEY GENERAL: Yes.

MICHAELSON (voice-over): California Attorney General Rob Bonta on his political future and his new lawsuit against the Trump administration. (END VIDEO CLIP)

UNIDENTIFIED MALE: Live from Los Angeles, "The Story Is" with Elex Michaelson.

MICHAELSON: And welcome to "The Story Is". I'm Elex Michaelson live in Los Angeles, where it's Friday night. Tonight, the top story is, new photos from Jeffrey Epstein's estate. The images just released by Democratic lawmakers on the House Oversight Committee show the many powerful men in the late sex trafficker's orbit. That

includes President Donald Trump, who is downplaying the photos. None of the released images picked any sexual misconduct, nor they believed to depict any underage girls.

Former Trump Advisor Steve Bannon, Billionaire Businessman Bill Gates, Richard Branson, also pictured, as was former President Bill Clinton. He has been subpoenaed for a deposition tied to the House investigation, along with Hillary Clinton. House Oversight Chair warns that he will begin contempt of Congress proceedings if they don't appear.

Now, some of the photos show Epstein alone, including one creepy photo of him in a bath tub with bubbles.

CNN's Kristen Holmes has reaction from the White House.

(BEGIN VIDEOTAPE)

KRISTEN HOLMES, CNN SENIOR WHITE HOUSE CORRESPONDENT (on camera): The White House accusing House Oversight Democrats of cherry-picking the photos that they chose to release. They did release roughly 90 photos out of 95,000. We are told that they are still going through those photos and to expect more being released. Now, as for President Trump, he said he hadn't seen them.

DONALD TRUMP, PRESIDENT, UNITED STATES OF AMERICA: Well, I haven't seen it, but -- I mean, everybody knew this man. He was all over Palm Beach. He has photos with everybody. I mean, almost there are hundreds and hundreds of people that have photos with him. So, that's no big deal. I know nothing about it.

HOLMES (on camera): Now, the White House has been hoping that this story would go away, but it doesn't seem it's going to anytime soon, particularly when you see this drip, drip of information from the committee, as they get this information from the Epstein estate, go through it and then push it out. Again, we are expecting more from the estate to be released through the committee.

The other thing to keep in mind here is that the Justice Department has until next Friday, December 19th, to release all the files. No word from the White House or DoJ whether or not they're actually going to comply with that deadline.

(END VIDEOTAPE)

MICHAELSON: Our thanks to Kristen Holmes there. Julie K. Brown is an investigative reporter with the Miami Herald. She was the first to expose many of Epstein's secrets, and earlier, she spoke to CNN about the pictures.

(BEGIN VIDEOTAPE)

JULIE K. BROWN, INVESTIGATIVE REPORTER, MIAMI HERALD (on camera): Let me put it from the perspective of the survivors, who I speak to quite often. From their perspective, all these people should be looked at. From their perspective, these men were in a place where there often were a lot of young girls around them, all the time, around Epstein, at the very least. But there have been many of them that told me that they went to certain events, dinners with people who were in the room, like Woody Allen, for example. And in their mind, all these people should be looked at. And this case has never been taken as seriously as it should have.

We know that he was trafficking in young girls and women. This does not mean that just because they were in a photo with him, that they -- that any of these men did anything wrong, but all of it should be looked at.

(END VIDEOTAPE)

MICHAELSON: We now take you live to Washington, where it is after midnight. House Republicans unveiled their much anticipated narrow healthcare package Friday, which does not include an extension for enhanced Affordable Care Act subsidies. Those subsidies, which expire at the end of the month, are what led to the longest government

shutdown in U.S. history. That's what Democrats said they were shutting down the government over. This new plan will not avert skyrocketing insurance premiums for millions of Americans. Instead, it focuses on expanding association health plans that allow employers to buy coverage together. It also adds new transparency rules for pharmacy benefit managers to help lower drug prices.

[00:05:00]

Now, despite deciding against reviewing the popular -- renewing the popular subsidies, sources tell CNN that GOP leadership is expected to allow a floor vote on an amendment for the subsidies in the House.

Lot to unpack with our political panel. Roxanne Beckford Hoge is the Chair of the L.A. County Republican Party, and Junelle Cavero is a Democratic State Representative from Arizona and veteran of the Clinton, Obama and Sanders presidential campaigns. Welcome to "The Story Is". Great to have you here for the first time, and Roxanne, welcome back. I appreciate the color coordinating. It's very easy to just remember which side you're on. So, I appreciate that.

Let's start with the Epstein photos. Creepy, kind of gross, but how do you sort of read it, and do you think it really matters?

ROXANNE BECKFORD HOGE, CHAIR, LOS ANGELES COUNTY REPUBLICAN PARTY: You say creepy, gross photos, I think Hunter Biden right away. I don't understand the need of some people to take creepy, gross selfies.
MICHAELSON: Yeah.

HOGE: That's -- just get that out.

MICHAELSON: Yeah.

HOGE: That's a nonpartisan belief of mine. It's a nothing burger. I especially find it bizarre to release photos with black bars on them. I mean, you could put black bars over our clothing right now, and we could all look very suspicious, but we're not nude. We're here dressed in our color coordinating outfits.

JUNELLE CAVERO, ARIZONA STATE HOUSE DEMOCRAT: I mean, what are we hiding, really? I mean, you're talking about photos, but you take 50 days until Congresswoman Grijalva had to get -- I mean, get through -- to actually serve to get these Epstein photos revealed. I mean, you're talking about photos that I think need to be released. It's been long enough.

MICHAELSON: Yeah. You say nothing burger, though.

HOGE: Yeah. I mean, gross man, disgusting man, sexually predatory man, and I recall Virginia Giuffre saying, you know what? This guy smelled a skunk and got out of it. So, I know it's the latest in a long line of, Oh, can we get Trump on this? But there is no question that Jeffrey Epstein was a creep and a criminal and a predator. This is not news.

MICHAELSON: Right. What do you make of the politics of this whole thing?

HOGE: It's a cynical ploy to sort of use real damage for real young women to try and get someone you don't like. And there are actual victims out there of Jeffrey Epstein who were not done well. I do notice the dates on a lot of these photos, Bill Clinton was president when that was happening. There were people accepting checks from that man who bent over backwards to ignore what was hidden in plain sight, and that's a shame. And yes, people who did that -- and many have stepped away from private life, Larry Summers just recently.

MICHAELSON: Yeah.

HOGE: When there is actual fire, they should be. But just a photo is not proof positive of anything.

MICHAELSON: You agree with that in terms of the --

CAVERO: No. I disagree. I mean, it's corruption in its best. You're hiding something. It has taken days. It has taken years, and you have Trump saying that he is going to be transparent and release these photos. I mean, what are we hiding here?

MICHAELSON: The argument could be made like the Biden administration didn't release this stuff either. I mean, they had this for years,

CAVERO: You are correct. But -- I mean, right now, it was what Trump actually campaigned on.

MICHAELSON: Yeah.

CAVERO: Biden didn't campaign on Epstein photos. I'm sorry. Why aren't we following it through? It's almost a year.

MICHAELSON: Yeah. Other big story, of course, is healthcare, which is one of the biggest issues in the country. What do you make of the Republican plan?

CAVERO: What Republican plan? I mean, you're talking about healthcare. You're talking about a death plan. I mean, you're -- it's in a couple of days, in a couple of months, in a few weeks --

MICHAELSON: Few weeks.

CAVERO: -- actually, people who are reliant on this entire system to provide life. I mean, you're talking about a healthcare system that just this week, when you're talking about ACA, that they didn't pass it through, and most importantly, your lives are at stake, and children are starving and there is nothing that's moving. And so, this Republican healthcare plan is a death plan, in my eyes.

MICHAELSON: Do you see it as a death plan?

HOGE: No. I think that we have to -- language matters so much. So, people conflate health insurance with healthcare, and the two are very different. American healthcare holds a candle to no one else. I mean, no one else can compare. I'm from a third-world country. I know. Believe me. I'd rather be sick here.

MICHAELSON: When you can pay for it --

HOGE: When I can pay for it?

MICHAELSON: -- when you can pay the best doctors here?

HOGE: Guess what?

MICHAELSON: Right.

HOGE: You are getting taken care of in America whether you can pay or not, whether you just arrived on a flight --

MICHAELSON: There is a difference in care if you're at Cedars-Sinai or your County USC Hospital.

[00:10:00]

HOGE: But guess what? If an ambulance --

MICHAELSON: Yeah.

HOGE: -- brings you to Cedars, they have to take --

MICHAELSON: Right. HOGE: -- care of you, and we have to remember that. And people get excellent care here all the time, and then many people are being asked to subsidize that. Look, health insurance is a Gordian Knot of that. It is a horrible thing to try and uncut. But we have to remember what the Affordable Care Act did. It didn't make care more affordable. It made health insurance mandatory for people who could have gotten by on catastrophic plans, and then it took away good plans, premium plans. And what it ended up doing was giving everyone basically catastrophic plans with unbelievably sky-high deductibles and premiums. And the only way to get that to pass through is, if the government pays for it, that's not a plan.

MICHAELSON: And it also raised prices for health insurance a lot too, and made a lot of money for the health insurance companies.

CAVERO: Absolutely. It's a manipulation of the system.

HOGE: Yeah.

CAVERO: I mean, at the end of the day, in a few weeks, these premiums are going to double in price. Millions of lives are going to be at stake. And so, this is the healthcare plan that's proposed by this administration, I'm sorry.

MICHAELSON: Let's talk about politics. Part of the reason that Donald Trump is the president is he beat Kamala Harris, who would have had a very different healthcare plan and would have -- those subsidies probably would have already been taken care of if she was in there. She was here --

HOGE: And she loves insurance companies. Yes.

MICHAELSON: -- in Downtown Los Angeles at the Democrats holding a big national meeting. You were there tonight. That's why you're here tonight.

CAVERO: Right.

MICHAELSON: And she spoke to the crowd. Here is some of what she had to say. OK. I guess we don't have that sound. But basically, she talked about the importance of affordability. She talked about leaning into some of those policies. What did you make of her reception and her message?

CAVERO: I mean, it was a standing ovation. Energy was eclectic when she spoke. She addressed the issues of affordability, something that this administration, let's be clear, hasn't -- to their detriment, even touched upon, and bringing it all together, trying to say, this is what we need to do. It's not perfect, but we need to address it. And today, with the administration of the inabilities of being able to deal with affordability, just mere basic -- the number one issue right now is grocery prices. We need to talk about these things.

MICHAELSON: What do you make of Kamala Harris coming back on the stage? HOGE: I'm a big fan. We're both of Jamaican parentage, and I have a little Kamala impersonation I can do another day. But the fact is that she would have been as terrible a president as she was a vice president, and I do appreciate that the Democrats have workshopped affordability, but no one will give you more affordability than conservatives who believe in small government. When you take away the burden of the regulatory state, when you take away the burden of the high energy prices -- and by the way, if anyone has any questions about what Gavin Newsom would do as president, just look at California, and nowhere is life less affordable and more corrupt and more filthy than here in California.

MICHAELSON: Certain parts of California.

HOGE: Yes. Those are gorgeous points.

MICHAELSON: But quick, Gavin Newsom also appeared quickly at this event. J.B. Pritzker appeared at this event. Who got the best reaction behind the scenes? Who was the crowd most excited about as a presidential candidate?

CAVERO: I think everybody was welcomed. I mean, this is the time. I mean, let's be clear --

HOGE: Good answer.

CAVERO: -- there are several that are out there.

MICHAELSON: Who were you most excited about?

CAVERO: I mean, I'm excited --

MICHAELSON: Who gave the best presentation?

CAVERO: Honestly, anybody than the current administration. I am super excited about all of them. But best presentation, it was everybody. Really, they were excited about what happened. We just came off an election cycle with how many wins across the board. I can't believe it's a great time.

MICHAELSON: OK. There you go. That's party loyalty.

HOGE: That's lost. You're good at this.

MICHAELSON: Yeah. Thank you both for coming and really appreciate you sharing your perspectives.

President Trump is refusing to say if the U.S. will seize more Venezuela oil assets. He spoke on Friday, two days after the U.S. seized the oil tanker near Venezuela's coast. He said it wouldn't be smart to reveal his next steps, but a senior U.S. official told CNN earlier that more tankers could be targeted. The president also hinted again at a possible land action in Venezuela, suggesting the U.S. could go after drug traffickers.

Meanwhile, Venezuela's opposition leader Maria Corina Machado says she wants a peaceful transition if the current regime is gone. She spoke in Oslo, Norway, where she received the Nobel Peace Prize earlier this week. Machado also revealed her possible role in a future democratic government.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

MARIA CORINA MACHADO, VENEZUELAN OPPOSITION LEADER: I will be where the Venezuela people already mandated. We won an election by a landslide, and our president-elect has asked me to join the government as vice president. So, I will accompany him in this new and challenging era that starts, or I would say that has already started.

(END VIDEO CLIP)

[00:15:00]

MICHAELSON: Machado was referring to fellow opposition leader Edmundo Gonzalez, who says he won a presidential election last year. The U.S. recognizes him as a legitimate president-elect, but Venezuela's government handed the victory to the current leader, Nicolas Maduro, despite allegations of widespread vote rigging. We will take you to Caracas next hour.

We are also learning how Machado got out of Venezuela and arrived in Norway. She has been largely in hiding since the government launched a crackdown on the opposition after last year's election. She was whisked out of the country on Tuesday by a rescue group founded by a former U.S. Special Ops veteran. That operation lasted for 16 hours, including a rough journey at sea to the island out there. She took a flight to Norway from there. The Special

Ops veteran described the whole thing.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

STERN: -- doing boats, doing planes, doing ground movements with high threat, we do this stuff as a matter of course at Grey Bull Rescue. However, because of her face, because of her signature, because the entire Venezuelan Intelligence Service, the entire Cuban Intelligence Service, parts of the Russian Intelligence Service, we're all looking for her for months and specifically this week in particular, because of the Nobel Prize, made this operation significantly more high-risk than we've ever done before. Overwhelmingly, this is the hardest, most high-profile, most delicate operation we've conducted.

Maria is known as the Iron Lady and she absolutely lives up to that name. She is a very, very, very resolute and tough -- just tough leader and tough woman. When we were on the boat together, we talked about this and I begged her not to go back.

(END VIDEO CLIP)

MICHAELSON: Despite that, she wants to go back, vowing to return to Venezuela as soon as possible.

Still ahead here on "The Story Is", the former head football coach at the University of Michigan is now facing multiple charges. Prosecutors share details about the moments leading up to his arrest and his firing from one of the country's top football programs. It's one of the most dramatic falls from grace you'll ever hear, and it is next.

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

[00:20:00]

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

MICHAELSON: Parts of the U.S. are bracing for a blast of Arctic air this weekend. The Upper Midwest could see dangerously cold temperatures, with wind chills 25 to 40 degrees below zero. Meanwhile, new atmospheric rivers are expected to bring more heavy rain to Washington State, the state already facing historic flooding after days of rain, which has triggered tens of thousands of evacuations and dozens of water rescues.

Check out this dramatic new video out of Washington. It shows a man stranded in flood water, stuck on top of his car. Authorities used a drone to send him a life jacket, something the King County Sheriff's Office says it's never done before. The man was eventually rescued by a helicopter crew.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

KING CHARLES III, KING OF THE UNITED KINGDOM: Indeed, today I am able to share with you the good news that, thanks to early diagnosis, effective intervention, and adherence to doctors' orders, my own schedule of cancer treatment can be reduced in the New Year. This milestone is both a personal blessing and a testimony to the remarkable advances that have been made in cancer care in recent years, testimony that I hope may give encouragement to the 50 percent of us who will be diagnosed with the illness at some point in our lives.

(END VIDEO CLIP)

MICHAELSON: That's Britain's King Charles, of course, giving the public a rare update on his cancer treatment. The king spoke about the treatment being reduced, and highlighted the importance of early screening. He made the announcement during a Stand Up to Cancer broadcast on Britain's Channel 4. King Charles was diagnosed with cancer early in 2024. The Buckingham Palace has not revealed what type of cancer the king is receiving treatment for, but says he has responded well to that treatment.

Fired University of Michigan head football coach Sherrone Moore faces multiple charges related to his arrest on Wednesday, just hours after he was dismissed from the storied program. Moore, charged with felony, invasion, along with misdemeanor counts of stalking and breaking and entering, made his first court appearance on Friday. Here is video of that. The magistrate entered a plea of not guilty on his behalf.

CNN's Whitney wild is in Michigan with the story.

(BEGIN VIDEOTAPE) WHITNEY WILD, CNN LAW ENFORCEMENT CORRESPONDENT (on camera): Elex, this case is only beginning. A source is telling CNN's Dana O'Neil that the University of Michigan has hired an outside law firm to investigate the allegations surrounding Sherrone Moore's time at the University of Michigan, as well as his dismissal. A source also saying that this investigation into Moore from the University of Michigan began with an anonymous tip in October. The criminal case also just beginning.

ODETALLA ODETALLA, DISTRICT COURT MAGISTRATE, WASHTENAW COUNTY: You may be seated.

WILD (voice-over): Charged with felony home invasion and misdemeanor stalking, ex-University of Michigan football coach Sherrone Moore appeared on Zoom at his arraignment Friday.

KATI REZMIERSKI, WASHTENAW COUNTY PROSECUTOR: The totality of the behavior is highly threatening and highly intuitive. She was terrorized.

WILD (voice-over): Moore was arrested on Wednesday, just hours after being fired as head coach of the Wolverines, setting off a firestorm of reaction among sports commentators.

UNIDENTIFIED MALE: -- what the hell is going on in Michigan right now?

ADAM SCHEFTER, NFL INSIDER: The whole situation itself is just sad and tragic.

[00:25:00]

WILD (voice-over): The school says an investigation found credible evidence more engaged in an inappropriate relationship with a staff member.

REZMIERSKI: A risk to this victim --

WILD (voice-over): Prosecutor Kati Rezmierski told the court, Moore, who was married with three daughters, was in a relationship with this woman for a number of years, and said the woman broke up with Moore on Monday.

REZMIERSKI: Eventually, she presented herself to the University of Michigan, cooperated in some form of investigation there.

WILD (voice-over): After Moore was fired on Wednesday, Rezmierski said he went to the woman's apartment.

REZMIERSKI: -- barged his way into that apartment, immediately then proceeded to a kitchen drawer, grabbed several butter knives and a pair of kitchen scissors and began to threaten his own life. I'm going to kill myself. I'm going to make you watch. My blood is on your hands. You ruined my life and a series of very, very threatening, intimidating, terrifying, quite frankly, statements and behaviors.

WILD (voice-over): 911 dispatch audio on Wednesday indicates an alleged assault. A CNN review matched the location of this call with the address of the alleged victim.

UNIDENTIFIED MALE (voice-over): There's a male at the location in the house attacking her and states he's been stalking her for months.

WILD (voice-over): The judge told Moore he cannot contact the woman upon his release.

ODETALLA: Are we understood on the no contact and no go to, sir.

SHERRONE MOORE, FORMER UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN COACH: Yes, your honor.

WILD (voice-over): Moore's attorney reminded the court he has no criminal history.

JOE SIMON, SHERRONE MOORE'S ATTORNEY: There is no evidence to suggest that he is a threat of public safety.

WILD (voice-over): In response to Moore's firing, University of Michigan President Domenico Grasso sent an email to students and faculty saying "There is absolutely no tolerance for this conduct at the University of Michigan. This breach of trust by Coach Moore is painful for many in our community."

UNIDENTIFIED MALE: Michigan can't escape the scandals.

WILD (voice-over): Students reacted to the news.

UNIDENTIFIED MALE: It's just really bad overall. I think it's just getting worse as well.

UNIDENTIFIED FEMALE: It's hard to want to support a program that does that, but I guess it's good to see the university addressing it and taking action.

WILD (on camera): Sherrone Moore was released on $25,000 bond today. He now has GPS tracking device as part of his bond conditions. He is also going to have to undergo mental health counseling. A not guilty plea was entered on his behalf by the magistrate judge in this case, Elex. His next court date is January 22nd. Elex.

(END VIDEOTAPE)

MICHAELSON: Whitney Wild reporting for us in Michigan. Whitney, thank you.

There was a heartbreaking moment during a Ukrainian boy's testimony before European lawmakers this week. 11-year-old Roman Oleksiv survived a Russian strike that killed his mom in central Ukraine in 2022, but at one point, his story became too much, even for the official translator.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

IEVGENIIA RAZUMKOVA, TRANSLATOR: I was in Venice with my mama in hospital, and the bomb came to this hospital.

UNIDENTIFIED MALE: [FOREIGN LANGUAGE]

KOSTIANTYN BIDNENKO, PRODUCER OF DOCUMENTARY ON UKRAINIAN CHILDREN: I will help you. No worries. It was the last time when I saw my mom, and the last time when I was able to say goodbye.

(END VIDEO CLIP)

MICHAELSON: The person who jumped in to help was the producer of a documentary on Ukrainian children, which was played for those lawmakers. The boy said he underwent multiple surgeries after the attack and was in a coma for more than 100 days.

Lawsuits are piling up against the Trump administration and now over their exorbitant fee on H-1B or skilled worker visas. At least that's what some are calling it. We'll hear directly from the Attorney General of California, Rob Bonta, who joins me in studio. Plus, is he about to run for California governor? I ask him.

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

[00:30:00]

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

MICHAELSON: Welcome back to "The Story Is". I'm Elex Michaelson. Let's take a look at today's top story.

Democratic lawmakers on the House Oversight Committee have released new photos from Jeffrey Epstein's estate. They show the late sex trafficker with high-profile men like President Donald Trump, Bill gates, and former President Bill Clinton. He has been subpoenaed, Clinton has, for a deposition tied to the House investigation, along with his wife, Hillary Clinton.

U.S. Special Envoy Steve Witkoff will meet with Ukrainian president Zelenskyy and other European leaders in Berlin this weekend, a White House official tells CNN. It comes at a pivotal moment, as President Donald Trump seeks to end the years-long conflict between Russia and Ukraine before the end of the year. The leaders of France, the U.K. and Germany are expected to be in Berlin as well.

The top U.S. historic preservation group is suing the Trump administration over the demolition of the White House East Wing. They plan to build a massive ballroom in its place instead. They say the project moved forward without required public review, and have asked a federal court to put a hold on construction. The White House says the president has full authority to renovate as he sees fit.

While the lawsuits keep piling up, a coalition of Democratic-run states is suing President Trump's administration over its new $100,000 fee for H-1B visas. Those visas allow qualified foreign professionals to work in the U.S. within specialized field like healthcare, tech, and education.

[00:35:00] The lawsuit is led by the Attorney General of California, Rob Bonta, who argues that the administration does not have the authority to impose such a surcharge on the visas, and he claims that the fee would block employers from filing critical jobs and would effectively dismantle the H-1B program altogether.

The Attorney General of California, Rob Bonta, joins me now right here in studio. Mr. Attorney General, welcome back to "The Story Is".

ROB BONTA, CALIFORNIA ATTORNEY GENERAL: Thanks for having me, Elex.

MICHAELSON: Good to see you.

BONTA: Great to see you.

MICHAELSON: So, this new lawsuit, it's one of, what, 150 or something.

BONTA: 49.

MICHAELSON: 49. H-1B visas, why is this issue matter?

BONTA: H-1B visas provide American employers like universities or schools or hospitals the ability to hire highly skilled workers when there is a labor shortage and domestic personnel are not available. So, it helps make sure kids are taught, that patients get care, that lives are saved through the healthcare system, and the Trump administration imposed an unlawful $100,000 fee, which is much higher than the current cost recovery fees, which will make these H-1B visas harder for employers in the United States to get.

MICHAELSON: They say that this is lawful, they can do this, that this is going to prevent abuse in the system. How

do you respond to that?

BONTA: They've said that 49 times, and we have won 80 percent of the time. So, we'll see them in court. We only go to court when we think we have the facts and the law and we'll win. And they're violating the Constitution. Congress has the power to raise revenue. Congress has the power to create immigration laws. The statute at issue here only allows them to get cost recovery, which is in the range of $1,000 to $7,500, nowhere near $100,000. They didn't go through the right process. They've broken the law in multiple ways, as they have in the past. So, we think they're wrong, and we think the judge is going to side with us.

MICHAELSON: Let's talk about some of the other things that you are doing in court, including, just this week, you got a win in court over the issue of what's called the FEMA BRIC program --

BONTA: Yes.

MICHAELSON: -- which is a lot of acronyms.

BONTA: It is.

MICHAELSON: What is the FEMA BRIC program? BONTA: In simple terms, it's a program from the federal government that provides funding to states to prepare for disasters before they strike, to prepare for wildfires or earthquakes or floods or landslides, and California, of course, unfortunately, has quite a few natural disasters. We had over a billion dollars on the line with this lawsuit. Trump tried to pull it away. We went to court. We got a final judgment, and we protected that over a billion dollars to prepare for disasters.

MICHAELSON: But could that then go to the Supreme Court to be overturned?

BONTA: It could. So, they still have a right to appeal. They go to an intermediate appellate court first and ultimately the U.S. Supreme Court. But most cases don't get to the U.S. Supreme Court. And we're really confident in our win here.

MICHAELSON: But a lot of these cases are. You just had another win on the issue of the National Guard in terms of California --

BONTA: We did.

MICHAELSON: -- and who is in charge of deploying that, but that is probably going to go to the Supreme Court. You were just in the Supreme Court yourself when it comes to the tariff fights --

BONTA: Yeah.

MICHAELSON: -- to watch that in person.

BONTA: Yep.

MICHAELSON: Are you confident in this court.

BONTA: The U.S. Supreme Court?

MICHAELSON: Yeah.

BONTA: We're confident in any court, where the court follows the law and looks at the facts, and that's what all courts are supposed to do, including the U.S. Supreme Court. So, yes. On this tariffs case, where Trump has imposed unlawful tariffs, we think we're going to prevail. That's right in front of the U.S. Supreme Court. We think we're absolutely right on the National Guard case, that there is no authority to keep 300 National Guards people in

Los Angeles still today, when there is no reason, no invasion, no rebellion, no inability to enforce the law. So, we're confident.

MICHAELSON: You had never been to the court before. Once you were there. What was your biggest takeaway from that experience?

BONTA: Yeah. You could feel the weight of it, how important it is, its central role in our American democratic institution to interpret the law and make the final say. And it was gratifying to see the back and forth referring to opinions and case law and statutory authority and the facts in the case. That's how decisions should be made, reasoned and based on law and based on the rule of law. So, it was very impressive to be there, and I'm grateful that they looked at the tariff case the way I look at the case.

MICHAELSON: Let's talk a moment about your future. So, earlier this year, a lot was made when you said that you were not going to run for governor of California. Now there is reports that you're thinking about it. Is that true?

BONTA: Yes.

MICHAELSON: So, I talked with you in February on my old show, my old employer, Fox 11 Los Angeles. The issue is, when we talked about your decision not to run for governor, this is what you told me then.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

BONTA: Once you run for an office and get elected, you got to do the job. This job is calling me to be at my best, to give everything I have, use all gas in the tank, give my passion, my focus, my priority, my energy, and I want to give it to this. I don't want to be focused on another election. I don't want to put political or personal ambition over my duty to the state and its people. This is the most important moment and the most important job I've ever had.

(END VIDEO CLIP)

[00:40:00]

MICHAELSON: So, what's --

BONTA: Well said.

MICHAELSON: -- changed since then?

BONTA: I still have all those feelings, and I'm very, very grateful for the outpouring of support and encouragement to -- from many people across the state to encourage me to consider running for governor. So, I'm giving -- I'm seriously considering it. And I think this is the state I love. It's given me so much. It gave me a home when my parents fled another country because of martial law being around the corner and democracy and freedom being at risk. It gave me a great public school education. It gave me a place to build my career with my wife, to raise my family, and I want to give it everything I got. It might be in this role, my current role. It could be in the role as governor. Should I decide that that's the best path? I don't know yet. I'm seriously considering it. I've made no decision. I have nothing to announce today.

But I'm grateful to have the opportunity to serve as A.G. and to consider the possibility of running for governor.

MICHAELSON: What's your timeline to make a decision?

BONTA: It's got to be quick. I mean, the election filing deadline is early next year. The primary is in June. So, it's weeks away, for sure. MICHAELSON: So, like the beginning of the year.

BONTA: Yeah.

MICHAELSON: Like maybe --

BONTA: That time period.

MICHAELSON: -- maybe that week or something like that?

BONTA: Could be in that period.

MICHAELSON: OK, because there is a lot of people that think you already have made up your mind. I mean, Rick Chavez Zbur, who is an assembly member, has filed paperwork to run for your job, assuming that you've already made this decision. Jesse Gabriel, another assembly member, making moves in that. What do you make of the fact that they're doing that? Are they barking up the wrong tree?

BONTA: I mean, maybe in the end. It depends on what I do. So, I don't have any problem with folks doing what they think is necessary for their future, and preparing for a possibility that could occur, and then being willing to pivot back if it doesn't. I have no problem with that.

MICHAELSON: Organized labor pushing you to do this?

BONTA: I have a lot of support in the organized labor world, which I'm very grateful for and proud of.

MICHAELSON: Lastly, wrap things up, holiday, quick takes, first thing that comes to mind, one-word answers, what is your favorite holiday song?

BONTA: Santa Baby.

MICHAELSON: Santa Baby, please come home. Favorite holiday movie.

BONTA: Love Actually.

MICHAELSON: Love Actually Baby. Favorite holiday food.

BONTA: Leche flan.

MICHAELSON: Very nice.

BONTA: A Filipino favorite that my mom makes homemade for me.

MICHAELSON: And lastly, what's your favorite holiday tradition?

BONTA: We always open up one gift on Christmas Eve with the family. The kids, when they were younger, loved doing that. We continue to do that today, and then we celebrate something called Media Noche, which is a feast as we approach midnight of Christmas Eve and right before it turns Christmas day.

MICHAELSON: Well, Rob Banta, Happy New Year. Happy -- Merry Christmas, all of the things.

BONTA: You as well. Happy Holidays, Elex.

MICHAELSON: And in the New Year, if you have an announcement, we know a place where you can come to make it.

BONTA: I feel very welcome here. Thank you.

MICHAELSON: So, thank you so much.

BONTA: Thank you, Alex.

MICHAELSON: Have a great holidays.

BONTA: Good to see you. You as well.

MICHAELSON: Our thanks to the A.G.

Taylor Swift pulls back the curtain on life during her record-breaking Eras Tour. When we come back, a preview of the more private, emotional moments taking place behind the scenes, and where you can clearly see them, on Disney+.

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

[00:45:00]

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

MICHAELSON: The Eras Tour may be over, but Taylor Swift is giving her fans an encore, "The End of an Era", the six-part documentary. In it, the pop star goes behind-the-scenes glimpse at her world conquering tour. It shows some very personal moments for Swift, including the tragic July stabbings in England of young girls at a Taylor Swift-themed event.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

TAYLOR SWIFT, POP STAR: There was this horrible attack in Liverpool at a Taylor Swift-themed dance party, and it was little kids that --

(END VIDEO CLIP)

MICHAELSON: Swift went on to meet privately with the families affected by those attacks. The documentary also features happier moments, such as the beginning of a relationship with her now fiance, Travis Kelce. The first two episodes are out now on Disney+.

The popular Actors on Actors Show is back for its 23rd season and its first season on CNN. Today's conversation is between Stellan Skarsgard and his son, Alexander Skarsgard. They're sitting down to talk all things family, from their legacy to award season rivalry. Also on the table, well, Alexander did not want to be an actor, and why he would have preferred that his dad had a normal job. Take a listen.

(BEGIN VIDEOTAPE) ALEXANDER SKARSGARD, ACTOR: I didn't want to be an actor.

STELLAN SKARSGARD, ACTOR: No. But -- I mean, it's about the same time you told me that, why can't you have a normal job and work with data and drive a Saab --

A. SKARSGARD: Yeah.

S. SKARSGARD: -- like everybody else does?

A. SKARSGARD: Yeah.

S. SKARSGARD: So, you didn't have a --

A. SKARSGARD: I didn't wear a suit, God damn it --

S. SKARSGARD: Yeah.

A. SKARSGARD: -- instead of like your weird hippie, sarongs and -- or nothing.

S. SKARSGARD: Yeah.

A. SKARSGARD: My dream was to just kind of for my family to be normal and fit in and be like everyone else's family. Like you said, for you to have a briefcase, that would have been fantastic.

S. SKARSGARD: You went into the military, became like a Swedish Navy Seal. I mean, you were really one of the tough guys.

[00:50:00]

But did you do that in opposition to me, to sort of provoke me in a way, or was it just a chance -- by chance?

A. SKARSGARD: I don't think it was an act of rebellion. I don't know. I was kind of lost, and I was like, I didn't know what I wanted to do, and I read about this unit, and I thought, like, this sounds pretty cool, and I don't know what I want to do. So, maybe, why not spend a year and a half doing this?

S. SKARSGARD: Yeah.

A. SKARSGARD: And so, that's kind of a challenge, in a way, mentally and physically. But then, looking back on it, maybe he was a bit of a (BEEP).

(END VIDEOTAPE)

MICHAELSON: It's interesting that he wished his dad looked more normal, and that was the outfit that he chose to wear to this event. So, you can watch that whole conversation, watch the series on the CNN app, CNN's YouTube page, and variety.com.

Would you dunk your wedding dress into a vat of dye? Well, a London studio and a natural dye specialist are meeting, apparently, a real demand for this. CNN's Stephy Chung followed the journey of one dress through the delicate process.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

JESS MAHENDRA, THINKERS AND TINKERERS SUPPER CLUB: It's a bit different, isn't it, with a wedding dress. I mean, it's the dress. I don't want it to end up in the closet and just gathering dust. Not being able to wear it again, it just would have been such a shame.

STEPHY CHUNG, ACTING SENIOR EDITOR, CNN STYLE (voice-over): Jess Mahendra is looking to give her wedding dress a new life. This London- based bridal studio gives customers the opportunity to transform their wedding dresses by dyeing them to wear again after the big day.

JESS KAYNE, CO-FOUNDER, THE OWN STUDIO: Bridal wear, as an industry, is pretty outdated by its definition, a little bit like fast fashion in the sense that you are wearing it once and never again. That's what we're trying to subvert with this.

CHUNG (voice-over): While the white wedding dress is generally attributed to Queen Victoria in 1840, our widespread adoption of this style is actually fairly new, popularized after World War Two. Historically, a gown just for this special occasion, was a luxury reserve for the ultra-wealthy. Instead, brides-to-be would wear the best dress of any color on their wedding day. While many connect the white gown with purity and innocence, it was also

originally seen as a status symbol in Western culture, a dress kept clean at a time before laundromats and dry cleaners.

KAYNE: One of the things that was really important to us when we set up the brand was for it to feel that people could come back to these pieces after the wedding day, if they want to re-wear something like this. It was really important that it was done in the right way with someone that had the technical expertise to do it.

CAVAN JAYNE, ARTISAN DYE STUDIOS: It's a very nuanced process, like, we have to taste the water that we use to see the level of like metal in the water, because that can shift the color. So, we've just received Jess's dress in the studio. So, now we're going to start preparing it for the dye process. Jess went for this lovely lemon verbena color.

This process is all carefully done by hand. I've measured the ratio of the weight of the dress, and then I know exactly how much dye to use. One degree can shift the color. We give the process so much respect because the garment is already holding so much meaning to that person.

KAYNE: Color is completely transformative. It's really interesting as -- after we launched the service, the majority of people coming into the studio are now coming in with it in mind.

JAYNE: There is a lot of things that excite us about the process, but I think for me personally, it is just the beauty and depth of color and how there is also like a kind of emotional response to color.

MAHENDRA: Absolutely perfect. I love it.

KAYNE: Yeah.

MAHENDRA: Oh my Gosh. I love it. Oh my Gosh. That looks amazing.

(END VIDEOTAPE)

MICHAELSON: Thanks to Stephy Chung.

We'll be right back for the next hour of "The Story Is".

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

[00:55:00]

(COMMERCIAL BREAK)

MICHAELSON: Football superstar Lionel Messi has landed in India for his highly anticipated GOAT Tour of the country, of course, "Greatest of All Time". Over the next three days, the World Cup winner will appear in multiple cities where fans are hoping for a rare close-up of the global icon. Kicking off the tour, the football star will be virtually unveiling a 70-foot statue of himself. Well, he'll also meet with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the weekend. It is his first return to the country in 14 years after his previous visit for a friendly match there.

It is the weekend, and you might be tempted to have a nice meal out. But how much would you be expected to pay? 50 bucks? 80 bucks? 150 bucks? Well, one restaurant in New York City has adopted a different model. They call it the Community Kitchen, which uses a sliding "Pay- What-You-Can". A multi-course dinner has three price points to choose from, $15, $45, or $125. The team behind the project says they hope to create a space where everybody is welcome.

(BEGIN VIDEO CLIP)

MARK BITTMAN, FOUNDER, COMMUNITY KITCHEN: The idea is really to show what food would look like in a

restaurant if well-being and equity were put before profit.

(END VIDEO CLIP) MICHAELSON: We'll see if other restaurants adopt it.

That's it for this hour of "The Story Is". The next hour starts right now.

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